

DELHI | Reaching Out to LA



THE INDIA FESTIVAL AT LOS ANGELES TO PROMOTE TOURISM WAS AN EXOTIC MIX OF CULTURE, ART AND A FEEL OF RURAL LIFE.

Complementing its Incredible India campaign, the four-day gala festival, India Calling, organised by the Ministry of Tourism concluded with much fanfare at Los Angeles. Held from September 18-21, the event comprised of a crafts village at California Plaza where 14 artisans from rural sites showcased their handicrafts. This was followed by a cultural event at Hollywood Bowl where over 15,000 people witnessed performances by artists like Pandit Ravi Shankar, Anoushka Shankar and Kailash Kher. Other events included a fashion show, photo exhibition and rural tourism project, which highlighted works of rural artisan communities of 36 rural sites in 20 states. *by Nandini Vaish*

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Pane Truth

When a commoner travels in a train which is pelted with stones, it goes unnoticed by the authorities. But when Congress General Secretary Rahul Gandhi is in a Delhi-bound Shatabdi from Ludhiana whose windowpanes are smashed by stones, the administration is quick on its toes. The CBI detained two boys from a village near Panipat. But AC coaches of trains have always been at the receiving end of stones, says a Railways official. In 2009, only six FIRs were lodged, including the one involving Gandhi. The Punjab-Haryana section has reported just two incidents of stone-pelting in the last two years. Nothing was done about them. Perhaps it will help ease the woes of common people if VIPs take trains more often. *by Rahul Tewari*

AN INDIA TODAY REPORT SPURS THE NHRC TO SEEK A PROBE INTO CHILD TRAFFICKING.

PATNA | The Lost Children

After taking suo motu cognizance of "a distressing news report that appeared in INDIA TODAY", the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) has asked the Bihar State Human Rights Commission to probe the issue and ensure "appropriate action". The report had carried case studies of children who were trafficked in the aftermath of the Kosi floods in 2008. According to Ghuran Mahto of Bachpan Bachao Andolan, a child rights organisation, over 12,000 children were trafficked to various cities after the floods. Though the Assistant Registrar's letter doesn't criticise the state's law enforcement agencies, he has almost made the assessment clear by quoting INDIA TODAY—"A critical evaluation of the state's counter-trafficking initiatives reveals lack of coordination between the police and block development authorities who should be addressing the economic welfare of victims, real and potential." Meanwhile, the NHRC has already allotted a case number to this issue.

by Amitabh Srivastava



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